

Photograph by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**

NEERU YADAV, 36
Sarpanch, Lambi Ahir village
Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Neeru has empowered village girls through hockey and ensured women are heard in the panchayat

Dressed in a traditional *daman* (skirt) and *kurti*, *odhni* draped over her head and a hockey stick in hand, Neeru Yadav cuts an unmistakable figure on the dusty village field. Born in Narnaul, Haryana, and married into Lambi Ahir village in Rajasthan, this former school-teacher found her calling when she saw how women facing domestic violence were rarely allowed to speak before male-dominated village elders. "That made me realise that a sarpanch has much more to do than merely focus on development," she says.

But contesting a panchayat election in a village riven by bitter caste politics was anything but easy. Some even opposed her for being "too educated"—an MSc in Mathematics along with BEd and MEd degrees—and argued that she would eventually move to Jaipur, where her husband, an executive engineer with the Public Works Department, was posted. But that did not deter her from entering the fray in 2020. The results were declared just two days after she delivered her second child.

HER ADVICE

"Stay focused on your work, and let your achievements prove your worth"

Since taking office, Neeru has ensured that women are heard during family disputes brought before the panchayat. But her most visible impact has come through hockey, encouraging village girls to take up the sport despite social resistance, including objections to their wearing sports shorts. She believes sport can open doors to government jobs through the sports quota. Neeru donates her honorarium as sarpanch towards the girls' training, while her NGO Aditri Foundation, named after her daughter, pays the coach's salary. Several girls now compete at inter-district and inter-state tournaments, and two have reached the senior national level. Equally innovative is her 'utensil bank' of nearly 8,000 steel utensils that villagers can borrow free for weddings and community feasts, reducing plastic waste while saving them money. ■

—Rohit Parihar